the RSS, he must also iron out issues in the problem states and fill all vacant positions. Many state units need urgent interventions; apart from UP and Maharashtra, the West Bengal state unit is struggling with turncoats and an incapacity to capitalise on the narratives against the Trinamool government. In Bhajan Lal Sharma-ruled Rajasthan, the satraps have yet to come to terms with the fact that a first-time MLA and newbie is the chief minister.

That said, for a party that has been in power for the past decade, it remains in its prime. For all the slip-ups in the general election, the BJP still managed to get almost 37 per cent of the popular vote. It has in the past decade managed to create a larger Hindutva umbrella, bringing together both the OBC and Dalit communities, and building a mammoth political support base of *labhaarthi*s (public scheme beneficiaries), especially in the heartland states. It also has in Modi a prime minister still streets ahead of his rivals in the Opposition, including Congress leader Rahul Gandhi.

CRITICS SAY THE FACT THAT THE BJP HASN'T BEEN ABLE TO NAME A NEW PARTY CHIEF, OR EVEN A WORKING PRESIDENT, REFLECTS THE CHURN INSIDE

The party has also been taking remedial measures, especially in its ties with the RSS. The return of RSS leader Ram Madhav—who had a fairly unceremonious exit from the party in September 2020—as election in-charge in crucial J&K (along with Union minister G. Kishan Reddy) was the first inkling that the RSS-BJP equation was back on level ground. As a top RSS leader said, "*Mausam badal raha hai* (the weather is changing)," alluding to the changing power equation in the saffron block.

NEW EQUATIONS WITH RSS

In mid-August, RSS leaders Dattatreya Hosabale and Arun Kumar sat with Nadda, Union home minister Amit Shah and defence minister Rajnath Singh to discuss the BJP's preparedness for the upcoming state polls. After the disappointment of the general election (coming down to 240 seats from 303 in 2019) and the formation of a coalition government, the BJP leadership has less room for manoeuvre. Coupled with the not-so-encouraging feedback from the poll-bound states, it was decided that "the best people had to be put on the job". Haryana and J&K will finish elections in the first week of October, after which the process will start in Maharashtra and Jharkhand along with the bypolls for 50-odd assembly seats across the country.

The RSS is sliding back into the driver's seat on other matters as well. It was on its recommendation that the party decided not to push for the passage of amendments to the laws governing the Waqf Board. The Sangh is believed to have impressed upon the BJP leadership that aggression on issues related to the Muslim minority had alienated the party enough to affect it electorally. And this could be just the beginning. The RSS is likely to claim more space as a consensus has to be arrived at on several other issues—ideological ones related to the caste census, implementation of 'reforms' in education, delimitation of assembly and parliamentary seats and, not least of all, planning the succession in both the Sangh and the BJP.

The RSS is pushing for wider consultations to zero in on a successor for Nadda—his present extension just buys time for this, helping tide over a tough election calendar meanwhile. It is clear that the RSS has to be on board for the entire gamut of decisions to be taken by way of the required restructuring. The BJP has sought seven names to fill the vacancies of general secretary (organ-

STATE B

NORTH

HARYANA

Khattar still larger-than-life

- New state unit chief Mohan Lal Badoli, like CM Nayab Singh Saini, is a staunch Khattar loyalist. Both unable to break out of his shadow
- With Khattar's exit from the state, the party needs new momentum to regain the support of Punjabi Hindus
- Jat leaders Capt. Abhimanyu, J.P. Dalal, O.P. Dhankar got poll tickets but are seeking a greater role in state unit

RAJASTHAN

Struggling with Bhajan

- Sidelined ex-CM Vasundhara Raje's discomfort is obvious, didn't campaign outside son's Jhalawar constituency
- Devi Singh Bhati, Kirodi Lal Meena blame state unit leaders for poor show in LS polls
- CM Bhajan Lal Sharma and state unit chief Madan Rathore seen as lightweights

WEST

GUJARAT

Homegrown troubles

- Modi-Shah's home state, yet the BJP couldn't manage a hat-trick of sweeping all 26 LS seats
- State unit chief C.R. Patil has joined Union cabinet, wants to step down. No consensus on successor
- Patidar leaders cut to size. Lightweight portfolio for Mansukh Mandaviya; Parshottam Rupala dropped
- CM Bhupendra Patel is still not the undisputed leader in state

MAHARASHTRA

Fadnavis's future shaky

- CM Eknath Shinde has put Fadnavis in the dock, especially on the Maratha reservation issue
- RSS opposed to Ajit Pawar's presence in Mahayuti alliance
- Too many turncoats making the local BJP uncomfortable